Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj

Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj · @shridhara-maharaja

Guardian of Devotion

Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj was a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura, an acharya in his line, and the founder of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math in Navadvip. His godbrothers and disciples called him Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, Sripad Sridhar Maharaj, or simply Sridhar Dev. The name “Bhakti Rakshaka” — “guardian of devotion” — was given him by his guru: Srila Bhaktisiddhanta saw in him a faithful exponent of his own conclusions.

On the eve of his departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta wished to hear from his lips the song of the feet of Sri Rupa Manjari, and his godbrothers understood that on that day the guru had passed on to him the authority of the Rupanuga Sampradaya, the line of Sri Rupa’s followers. From then on they honoured him as the sampradaya-acharya, and many of them accepted sannyasa from him. He was revered by all as an eminent acharya of this line, yet he himself never thought himself worthy of glory and remained deeply humble all his life. His disciple and successor, Srila Govinda Maharaj, said that after the great wave of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj’s preaching had swept over the whole world, “now a new wave has come — the preaching of Srila Sridhar Maharaj”.

Family and Appearance

He appeared on 12 October 1895 in Sripat Hapania, in the district of Burdwan, West Bengal — on the Krishna Navami of the month of Damodara. The same lunar day also commemorates the appearance of Virachandra Prabhu, the son of Nityananda[1].

He came of a respected brahmana family. His father’s name was Sri Upendra Chandra Deva Sharma Bhattacharya Vidyaratna, his mother’s Srimati Gauri Bala Devi; they named their son Sri Ramendra Chandra Deva Sharma Bhattacharya[2].

His birth was preceded by a sign. A relative of the family had gone on pilgrimage to receive the darshan of the Deity, and in a dream the Deity handed her a beautiful, radiant infant. Remembering that her sister-in-law had no children, she gave the child to her. When Ramendra was born, she recognised in him the very infant of her dream.

Learning came easily to him, and from childhood his heart was drawn to God and to the sacred books. At primary school he was always first in his class and twice skipped a year; early on, too, he showed an inborn inclination for Sanskrit. “My memory can go back to the time when I was learning to read — I was five then,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj recalled. From five to eight he lived in his uncle’s house and received his first schooling there, and his aunt helped him study the “Ramayana” and the “Mahabharata”. Even then he was drawn to the ancient teachings — the Vedas and Upanishads — and to the way of life of the orthodox part of society.

At ten he moved on to middle school. In the school debating club he always took the side of the shastras and often argued with teachers who championed “the Renaissance or the Reformation”. “I fought without fear of defeat,” he said. At fourteen, by family tradition, he received the sacred thread of a brahmana.

His mother cooked many tasty vegetable dishes for the whole family, but he would eat only rice stewed with bitter nim leaves, which greatly upset her. While still a child he rose every day before sunrise and walked three miles to the Ganges to bathe, picking lotuses on the way from the ponds nearby as offerings to the Ganges and to Lord Shiva. Once, as he was walking to Jamapur, the universal form of

the Lord suddenly appeared before his eyes.

Youth: Rama, Gaura, Krishna

He was born into a revered family of smarta brahmanas, yet from his earliest childhood he was drawn to the sankirtana of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu.

“In life I value self-sacrifice and magnanimity,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj said. That is why at first he especially loved Lord Ramachandra, for His flawless deeds. For Krishna he did not at first feel the same attachment: the Vrindavan-lila was then beyond his understanding. And yet, looking at the murti of Radha-Govinda, he felt the charm that came from Them. His first attraction to Krishna was awakened by the “Bhagavad-gita”, and later by Mahaprabhu. He admired Radharani and loved Mahaprabhu with all his heart — and They led him to Krishna: “Mahaprabhu and Radharani showed me mercy — it is They who helped me attain love for Krishna.” So the young man’s perplexity before the Lord’s most intimate pastimes was dispelled by the mercy of Those who Themselves bring love for Him to the world.

While still at school he read in a book that japa of the gayatri 432 times a day brings swift progress on the spiritual path, and for some time he did just that, trying to grasp the meaning of the mantra without a grammar or a dictionary. “I was convinced: the Gayatri mantra is not lifeless words — it is spiritual and full of consciousness,” he recalled; and so, if he chanted it, it would itself reveal its meaning and purpose. Many years later he would write the “Gayatri-nigudhartha”, an explanation of the hidden meaning of the gayatri (of which more below).

College, a Turning Point, the Search for a Guru

After school he entered Krishnanath College in Berhampore, in the district of Murshidabad. In those years an astrologer looked at his palm and foretold that the young man would become a perfect, enlightened personality, would be famed throughout the world as a preacher of Hari-katha, and would leave this world at the age of ninety-three. (He departed in 1988, in the ninety-third year of his life.) Textbooks held little interest for him: he read the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” and the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” far more — and still passed his examinations, while many diligent students failed. Four years later he became a Bachelor of Arts in philosophy and took up the study of law.

The turning point came unexpectedly. One day a fellow student referred to his own father as “that gentleman” and explained: where was I in my past lives, and who were my parents then? He is my father only in this life. The words cut him to the quick. “He is right. We are all almost strangers,” he thought, and the longer he thought, the more keenly he felt emptiness and loneliness. “It was a great shock and a great upheaval in my life,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj recalled. Worldly achievements lost all meaning for him, and he neglected his studies.

At that time a friend gave him books on the life and teachings of Mahaprabhu. He read them eagerly, as if drinking nectar, and found in them what he had longed for: hope, support and shelter. His attachment to Sri Chaitanyadeva, he thought, had come to him from a past life. His mother’s family revered Mahaprabhu, but his father’s kin — orthodox smarta brahmanas, worshippers of Shakti and logicians of the Nyaya school — were hostile to His followers. Even so, he surrendered to Chaitanyadeva not only with his mind but with his heart: “I underwent a complete conversion.” He began to look for devotees of Gauranga and for a sadhu whom he could accept as his guru, but for a long time he found none.

Soon afterwards his father died, broken by the change in his eldest son, on whom he had placed the family’s hopes. On his deathbed he asked his son to promise that he would marry. Sridhar Maharaj had never told a lie and could not give his word where he was not sure of keeping it; but his father begged

him not to grieve him in the hour of death, and he answered, “I will try to fulfil your request.” He had to keep his word — he married; his family life lasted six years.

Meanwhile Mahatma Gandhi’s civil disobedience movement was gaining strength, promising independence — swaraj — within a year. In 1921, before finishing law college, he joined it: he wished to become a sannyasi, but resolved to give that year to his countrymen. On behalf of the movement he worked as a secretary in Kalna; so two or three years went by. Then he withdrew from its affairs, but later he was called to Calcutta, where he acquired another profession and held an executive post.

His search for a guru went on. A college friend introduced him to a man of his own age — Paramananda, the founder of the Bharat Sevashram, a man of action (a karmi). Paramananda urged him to join his organisation and argued that Mahaprabhu’s teaching is the highest, but one must first acquire detachment by following the Buddha and then study Shankara’s Vedanta; otherwise prema may easily be mistaken for ordinary worldly love. He objected: why, then, did Chaitanyadeva Himself say nothing of the kind? On the contrary, He taught: whoever you are, take the Name and the company of sadhus — and so you will come to Me. Paramananda had no answer. Then he asked him to say where a guru could be found; Paramananda gave him an address, but he found no one there.

Meeting Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

One day he came across a poster: the Gaudiya Math was inviting people to a festival that ran for a whole month at No. 1 Ultadanga, not far from the Pareshnath temple. He went, reasoning that a movement called “Gaudiya” must have to do with Sri Chaitanyadeva. He found only one man there — the rest had gone out on nagara-sankirtana — and even in a short conversation he saw that here the scriptures were known more deeply and thoroughly than he knew them. Then the devotees returned, and for the first time he saw Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — “Guru Maharaj”, as he always called his guru — with the danda of a wandering monk in his hand. “At first sight I understood that Guru Maharaj was completely indifferent to the world. Nothing could disturb him — he was completely self-sufficient.” From that day on he began to visit the Math.

He was drawn by these people’s faith in the scriptures. Worldly authorities counted for nothing here: if anyone began to speak of the ideas of Aurobindo, Vivekananda, Ramakrishna or Gandhi, he was quickly cut short — the measure of everything was Mahaprabhu, the “Bhagavatam” and the “Gita”. Gradually the true meaning of the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” began to open to him, and he understood that Sri Chaitanyadeva and the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” are the highest ideal of spiritual knowledge.

He longed to see and hear Guru Maharaj himself. But once, when he wanted to go upstairs to his room, Kirtanananda Brahmachari stopped him: this threshold was not to be crossed without permission. It sounded harsh, and he thought, “Why do they divide people here into their own and outsiders? I shall not come here again.” But at once he remembered a story from the “Mahabharata”: Vyasadeva sent Shukadeva to study with the royal sage Janaka, and at each of the seven gates of the capital Shukadeva was kept waiting seven days — forty-nine days he waited for the meeting. And he reasoned: were there something wrong here, while he was surrounded with flattery and honour, it would be right to leave; “but if I can attain the true good here, then even if they beat me with a broom — I must not leave!”

Soon their first conversation took place. After his meal Guru Maharaj was walking on the roof, and he was standing nearby. Through a companion Srila Bhaktisiddhanta asked whether he wished to say something, whether he had any questions, and at last what purpose had brought him. “To attain your mercy at any cost,” he answered. “I need nothing else.” Then the guru came over himself, asked who he was, where he came from and what he did, and said, “You are undoubtedly fortunate. You were born

within Gaura-mandala." The companion handed him a newly printed booklet — a gift from Guru Maharaj. He already had one, but he was told: take it — this is something more than a mere gift.

His decision ripened at one of the Math's festivals. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta was speaking to a large gathering of educated guests from Krishnanagar; elsewhere Sripad Bhakti Pradip Tirtha Maharaj was speaking, Sripad Bhakti Svarupa Parvat Maharaj was receiving donations, and the Math was alive like a beehive. When the festival was over and the guests, having bowed to the guru, were going home, he suddenly said, "Do not deceive me." You came to dedicate yourselves to the service of Krishna, and now you are leaving to plunge again into worldly affairs, thinking: when I am free, I shall come to the Math. No! Even if a fire is burning somewhere and you hurry to put it out — there is no need: "Even if fire engulfs the whole world, you will lose nothing." "Your needs and desires will be fulfilled only in the service of Krishna's lotus feet, and in no other way." Never before had he heard Krishna-bhajana spoken of with such force and urgency — and he understood that here was where he must bow his head. He resolved to become a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta.

He was drawn to the company of the noble and learned men who had given their lives to Mahaprabhu's service. What kept him from coming and staying? His father was dead; his mother and three younger brothers would manage without him — but his wife would be unhappy. That same evening, on returning home, he learned that his wife had suddenly fallen ill; three days later she was gone. His mother tried to marry him again, but in vain.

In those days he was invited to Mayapur for the festival of Sriman Mahaprabhu's appearance. His mother, too, was calling him — to the village of Gumo, where she had stopped with one of her sons before a journey to Haridwar: her health was failing, and the meeting might be their last. The choice was hard, but he went to Mayapur. Six months after his wife's death his mother passed away in Haridwar during the Kumbha Mela; before her death she was anxious about who would perform her shraddha if her eldest son became a sannyasi. He came, fulfilled a son's duty, and returned to join the Math. At first he had thought to do so once his younger brothers had finished their studies and found work, but Sripad Bharati Maharaj and others persuaded him not to delay: some new obstacle would surely arise later, and this life would pass in vain.

So he became a member of the Gaudiya Math, and little by little his doubts were dispelled. Soon many, even senior godbrothers, began to ask him to explain difficult passages in the lectures of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — "Srila Prabhupada", as his disciples called him — and his explanations gave everyone great satisfaction; the educated part of the mission acknowledged that he presented Mahaprabhu's teaching very simply and clearly.

In 1926 he left home for good and dedicated himself entirely to the service of the mission. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta was overjoyed that such a learned man had come to Sriman Mahaprabhu's mission, and greeted it with a verse of the "Bhagavad-gita" (3.21):

yad yad ācarati śreṣṭhas tat tad evetaro janaḥ sa yat pramāṇaṁ kurute lokas tad anuvartate

"People follow the example of a great man. Whatever conclusion such a man accepts as truth, the rest agree with it."

So after a long search, by the mercy of the Supreme, he found his guru. According to one of the biographies, he received initiation from Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in 1927[3].

Preacher of the Gaudiya Math; Sannyasa

At first he lived in the Calcutta Math and served in the printing press, reading proofs. This work, he admitted, did not particularly inspire him: what drew him most was preaching. This was noticed, and

soon he was sent out to preach. First they stayed at a Math in Bengal, then in Benares, and finally in Vrindavan, where they held nagara-sankirtana; then he was sent to Delhi to collect donations. When a Math was founded at Kurukshetra, he was put in charge of it; for two or three years he laboured there alone — Kurukshetra is deserted except on the days of solar eclipses, when hundreds of thousands of pilgrims flock there. Then a Math was established in Delhi, and he headed it; later he preached in Shimla and other places.

Then Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sent them to Madras. The party lived in a rented house; it was led by the senior sannyasi, Sripad Bon Maharaj. He himself was known as "Sri Ramendrasundar Bhattacharya, Bachelor of Arts": he addressed the public, introduced the sannyasis, and sometimes collected donations. But Bon Maharaj once remarked that this devotee could preach well — better that he preach than collect donations. He also encouraged Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava while the latter was building the Madras Gaudiya Math: the temple in Madras rose through the labours of them both, of Bon Maharaj and of others.

Even before sannyasa he was one of the outstanding preachers of the Math, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta was very pleased with him. He spoke of him as "a worthy person to continue the spiritual succession"; valuing his deep knowledge of the scriptures and spiritual insight, he called him shastra-nipuna, "expert in the conclusions of the scriptures", and once niveditatma, "a pure soul wholly surrendered to the Supreme". In October 1930, at the first Gaudiya Math on Ultadanga Road, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave him sannyasa and the name "Srimad Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar" — "Guardian of Devotion" — for his supreme devotion and strict fidelity to the ideals of the Rupanuga Sampradaya. The guru saw in him the strength to guard the line of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas against distortion. The translator of one of the biographies — a disciple both of his and of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami — also calls him "sarva-shastra-siddhanta-vit", knower of the conclusions of all scriptures.

When Bon Maharaj left to preach in England, he took charge of the Math in Madras. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta wanted to send him to London too, but he replied: "I am not fit for this. I do not understand their pronunciation, and I have no wish to mix closely with them. You will spend a great deal of money on my journey, but I shall not be able to justify Your hopes. Of course, if You order me, I will go." And in his place the guru sent Sriyukta A. B. Goswami Prabhu — later Srila Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj.

Once, when he was in the Madras Math, someone came and criticized them: "Oh, you are only talking about Krishna, and people are dying without food. Don't you mind?" The Ramkrishna Mission, the man went on, was doing real relief by feeding so many: "First make them live, feed them, and then you can tell him about Krishna." Sridhar Maharaj answered with a question: if, while one is distributing food in a famine, someone from the crowd flees, should one go on distributing, or run to catch him? "You must distribute the food; that is natural," the man replied. "The crowd is always ready to hear from me about Krishna," said Sridhar Maharaj. "…Why should I stop distribution of the nectar, and run to catch one man?" Real relief in this world of death, he taught, is not clothing or feeding people, but Krishna-katha, talk of Krishna.

He travelled widely through India, preaching in Bengali, Hindi, Sanskrit and English; he had an excellent command of English and was uncommonly eloquent. Tirelessly carrying the message of Sri Chaitanyadeva, he lectured in colleges and universities, held public seminars and arranged sankirtana festivals. Once in Garidi, in Bihar, after his lecture in the local law library, a listener bitterly admitted: we fancied ourselves civilised because we mix with the English and thought our ancestors savages — your talk has shown us what a great heritage we possess and how low we have fallen. Another time, also in Garidi, the chairman of a scientific conference, having heard him, concluded: until now we regarded Vaishnava-dharma as a branch of Hinduism, but the arguments and the evidence of scripture have

convinced us that it is the original religion — jaiva-dharma, the religion of all souls.

Preaching with his guru in South India, he noted how Srila Bhaktisiddhanta received gentlemen renowned as devotees in their parts. He would ask each of them, “Under whose guidance does your devotional service to Krishna go on?” Generally they said that they were directly concerned with Lord Krishna or Lord Rama — and when they had gone, the guru would say, “He has no devotion.” Devotion that ignores the shelter of the Lord’s devotees remains vague and takes no real shape. Many sayings of his guru he would later repeat to his listeners: “You have come here cutting a return ticket”; the intellect cannot enter the world of spirit, just as a bee cannot taste the honey by licking the outside of a corked bottle; “I am a servant of the servant of the Vaishnavas” — so the guru always spoke of himself; “We are suddha-sakta, worshipers of the pure potency”; and of one departed disciple: “Bhaktivinod Thakur came to me, but I could not recognize him.”

Together with Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava, Bhakti Pradip Tirtha and Jajabar Maharaj he also went out collecting donations for the mission.

In 1934 the mission’s journal “The Harmonist” printed his essay on Sri Guru, signed “Swami B.R. Sridhar”; half a century later it opened the book “Sri Guru and His Grace”. Every living being, he wrote, tends towards perfection, but the tendency is weak — and this “makes room for the guide, or guru”; “the guidance to perfection or Absolute Truth is necessarily a function of the absolute Himself, and the divine agent through whom this function manifests is Sri Guru, or the divine guide.” Sri Guru manifests himself in a twofold way, as the director from within and the preceptor from without, and only by the grace of the guru within can we recognize the real preceptor without and submit to his holy feet. Not even in his liberated condition can an individual soul be one with Godhead; and “Sri Guru is not exclusively the same as the Supreme Lord Himself, but he fully represents the essence of the whole normal potency and embodies the most comprehensive and excellent service and favor of the Lord. As he is the fittest servitor of the Lord, he is empowered by the Lord to reinstate all misguided souls to their best interest.” The disciple, he would later teach, sees in the guru the delegated power of Krishna, while the guru himself conducts himself as a Vaishnava — an inconceivable unity in diversity.

Sarbhog and the Hymns to Srila Bhaktivinoda

In March 1936 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sent him with Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava and others to Sarbhog in Assam, to prepare the installation of the Deities of Sri Sri Guru-Gauranga and Gandharvika-Giridhari. By the guru’s order he directed the ceremony and dressed and adorned the Deities beforehand. Seeing this, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said, “The Deities are already installed,” and Sridhar Maharaj grew sorrowful, thinking he had committed an offence. He asked Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava to write to the guru and beg forgiveness for him. The reply came: one who is surrendered commits no offence — the Lord does not see his faults.

Of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta’s disciples, two became especially known for their hymns to Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura: Bhakti Vichar Jajabar wrote in Bengali, and Sridhar Maharaj in Sanskrit. In that same year, 1936, for the anniversary of Srila Bhaktivinoda’s departure, he composed the “Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-viraha-dashakam”, ten verses on separation from him, glorifying Bhaktivinoda and his place in the succession of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. The style and depth of the poem so struck Srila Bhaktisiddhanta that he said to his sannyasi disciples Sripad Bhaktiyadava Goswami Maharaj and Sripad Shrauti Maharaj: “It is Bhaktivinoda Thakura who speaks through him. I am glad that when I leave this world there will remain at least one person able to present the siddhanta in all its fullness.” According to one of the biographies, on reading these Sanskrit verses the guru said that he was now at peace: after him there would remain at least one person able to present his conclusions — bhakti-siddhanta.

Srila Sridhar Maharaj himself recalled that he composed the poem about a year before his guru's departure. When he read it to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, the latter remarked, "You have chosen the style very well." Later he heard the guru tell Sripad Shrauti Maharaj that the poem was beautiful indeed and had not been written by him: its author was Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura himself, who had revealed his work through him — "to me this is perfectly clear." And to Sriyukta Aprakrita Prabhu Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said, "I am glad that my message will survive me — I see the siddhanta in this verse." Here is the ninth verse of the poem, on Srila Bhaktivinoda's most hidden gift:

śrī-gaurānumataṁ svarūpa-viditaṁ rūpāgrajenādṛtaṁ rūpādyaiḥ pariveśitaṁ raghu-gaṇair āsvāditaṁ sevitam jīvādyair abhirakṣitaṁ śuka-śiva-brahmādi-sammānitaṁ śrī-rādhā-pada-sevanāmṛtam aho! tad dātum īśo bhavān

"Approved by Sri Gaura, understood by Svarupa, revered by Sanatana, the elder brother of Rupa; offered to the world by Rupa and his companions, relished and served by Raghunatha and his followers, guarded by Jiva and others, honoured by Shuka, Shiva, Brahma and the rest — the nectar of service to the feet of Sri Radha! O wonder: and this you have the power to bestow" ("Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-viraha-dashakam", 9).

Another poem of his, the "Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-dashakam", was printed in the journal "Gaudiya" in July 1939.

The Guru's Last Day

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta left this world on 1 January 1937[4]. Just before his departure he wished to hear from the lips of Srila Sridhar Maharaj Narottama Dasa Thakura's bhajan "Sri Rupa-manjari-pada" — a hymn of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas that expresses the whole siddhanta, the highest mood of devotion, and the special position of Srila Rupa Gosvami.

Srila Govinda Maharaj told the story thus. The disciples took turns watching at the guru's bedside, each for two hours a day, and Sridhar Maharaj chose the hardest time — from two to four in the morning, when sleep presses hardest. When relieved, he did not sleep but only rested: an hour later the arati would begin. On the day before his departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called together his closest disciples and, not seeing Sridhar Maharaj among them, said, "Call Sridhar Maharaj." When he came, the guru asked, "Sridhar Maharaj, sing *śrī-rūpa-mañjarī-pada, sei mora sampada*." Everyone understood that the guru would soon leave the world, and they hung on his every word. Sridhar Maharaj was not a skilled singer and hesitated in embarrassment; then Kunjabihari Vidyabhushan — secretary and manager of the Gaudiya Math, later Sripad Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha Maharaj — asked a brahmachari with a good voice to sing. But Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said, "I do not want beautiful singing — I want to hear this bhajan from Sridhar Maharaj." Everyone was stunned. Deeply moved, Sridhar Maharaj began to sing, and the guru said, "I am happy." Then he told others to sing Srila Bhaktivinoda's song "*tuhu doyā-sāgara tāraite prāṇī*" and others[5].

Srila Sridhar Maharaj himself recalled: "When Prabhupada fell ill, I was at his bedside serving him. Exactly one day before his departure he called me and asked me to sing 'Sri Rupa-manjari-pada'." He was not yet used to leading kirtana and lacked the resolve; Sriyukta Kunja Babu asked a brahmachari to sing, but the guru was displeased: "I do not need correct intonation or sweet sounds." "And I had to sing 'Sri Rupa-manjari-pada'. Someone said, 'Thus Prabhupada has accepted you into the world of rasa-seva.'"

His godbrothers said many times afterwards — and Srila Govinda Maharaj heard it from them himself: "Before, we did not know how the transfer of authority takes place, but that day we witnessed it. Srila Prabhupada passed on the authority of the Rupanuga Sampradaya to Srila Sridhar Maharaj." From then

on they showed him the greatest reverence as the sampradaya-acharya of the Rupanuga line.

Seclusion: Vrindavan, Ekachakra, Navadvip

After Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's departure the affairs of the mission were to be managed by the trustees he had appointed: by the guru's will they were to form a governing body. "But, unfortunately for us... there were many disagreements, and the Mission could not preserve its unity," Srila Sridhar Maharaj recalled. As his conscience bade, he did all he could to keep the movement from falling apart, but he sided with no party: "to take anyone's side in a fight against others was not my rule." A lawsuit began, and some of his godbrothers were imprisoned; in those days he did not leave: "I could not run away like a coward." Only when the case was dropped about a year later did he leave the Math and go to Vrindavan, though his godbrothers did everything to keep him.

For a month he lived near Govardhana, keeping the vow of urja-vrata, and there he accepted a Govardhana-shila. On the way back he met a relative, Mani Babu, who worked on the railway, and asked him to donate ten rupees a month; he agreed and sent the money for two or three months. With this "capital" he came to Navadvip and rented a house for two rupees a month. His godbrothers searched for him a long time, and when they found him they began to visit him — and never came without gifts.

Some leaders of the Gaudiya Math asked him to become acharya, but he had never wished for such a post. His godbrothers hoped that he would give initiation to the new people whom the preaching would bring — but he refused, because he "did not feel the confirmation of the heart." Yet one anxiety would not leave him: Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had not approved of nirjana-bhajana, solitary practice, and had always taught that devotees must gather together and sing kirtana.

He did not mean to stay long in Vrindavan. "Only perfected souls can live in Vrindavan," he said; fallen souls should rather seek the shelter of Mahaprabhu in Navadvip, at the aparadha-bhanjan-pat, the place where all offences are forgiven. But Mahaprabhu's mercy comes only by the mercy of Nityananda Prabhu. Narottama Dasa Thakura sings of it: *heno nitāi bine bhāi, rādhā-kṛṣṇa pāite nāi* — "without such a Nitai, O brother, one cannot attain Radha and Krishna." Srila Sridhar Maharaj explained: "by the mercy of Nityananda we shall receive the mercy of Gauranga, and by the mercy of Gauranga we shall attain the mercy of Radha-Govinda." Such, he said, is the path shown long ago by Lord Brahma: "A devotee of Krishna can easily correct and wholly change even what destiny has ordained for him."

He resolved to settle for good in Koladvipa, near Gupta-Govardhana. But to take eternal shelter in Navadvip-dham one needs the blessing of the dhameshvara, the Lord of the dham — Nityananda Prabhu. So he first went to Ekachakra, the place of Nityananda's appearance, and prayed: "You are patita-pavana, the saviour of the fallen. I pray for Your mercy. Allow me to spend the rest of my days in Koladvipa, in Navadvip-dham, where I can find shelter." And suddenly he heard a voice within: "You pray for the mercy of Nityananda Prabhu and want to win His favour?" Nityananda saves the fallen, while the one praying had no wish to help others — how could he hope for His compassion? He pondered this long and at last surrendered to the will of Nityananda Prabhu — and came to Navadvip.

In Navadvip he rented a room for two rupees a month. By day he studied the shastras; in the evening he chanted the Holy Name and lay down to sleep only after completing a lakh — a hundred thousand Names. For Sri Giridhari, whom he had brought from Vrindavan, he made a small throne in his room; he cooked once a day, offered the food to the Lord and himself took a little prasada. "The days flowed by evenly."

At that time he was studying the books of Srila Jiva Gosvami. One who has wealth but does not give it to the Lord is guilty, says Jiva, of vitta-shathya, miserliness; likewise one who has understood the science of bhakti but does not share it with others is guilty of jnana-shathya. He remembered a Puranic

story heard in childhood: a great learned brahmana would share his knowledge with no one, and in his next life became a mango tree laden with beautiful fruit that no one — neither man nor even bird — would touch; so the Lord answered Anantadeva, who asked about that tree's fate. Another thought came too: if a physician has not yet reached perfection, can he not help the sick? If everyone waits until he is perfect, many will never live to receive help. "With these thoughts I decided that I would no longer seek solitude, but would begin to help others." He had no wish to preach widely or to have many disciples, but he resolved to explain the fundamentals of the knowledge kept by the succession to everyone who came, and to give initiation — remembering the instruction given him by Nityananda Prabhu, the patita-pavana: "You must do everything possible to help those whom you consider to be sincere seekers." So the humility and the love of quiet reflection on the scriptures that had led him to decline the post of acharya gave way, by Nityananda's will, to compassion for every sincere soul.

He also told of this turn in his own words. At first he had shared the idea that only a devotee of the highest order may initiate, and after the departure of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta he "did not venture to make disciples"; but, he said, "I had some transformation through three events. Then I came to take up this work humbly, modestly." There came to his mind the story of Krishna's headache in Dvaraka, when the only cure was the footdust of His devotees: in Dvaraka no one would give Narada any — no one wanted to go to hell for it — but the gopis of Vrindavan came at once: "Yes. Eternal hell. We don't care for that! If slight relief is there for our Lord, that is our only concern." And there came Mahaprabhu's command: "On my order, become guru, and deliver the land" (CC, Madhya 7.128). "I am fallible," such a disciple thinks, "but I am confident that what my guru has given to me is an uncommon, vital, and nectarine thing. And he has asked me to give it to others… I am his servant. He will look after me." "Being so low, still I have accepted this duty as I have been ordered by my acharya to do," said Srila Sridhar Maharaj.

Helping everyone, he did not, however, overexert himself: the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu", in listing the sixty-four limbs of bhakti, warns against superfluous undertakings — not to build too many temples, not to hold large preaching programmes — and he would quote a verse from it[6]:

bahu-grantha-kalābhyāsa-vyākhyā-vāda-vivarjanam vyavahāre 'py akārpaṇyaṁ śokādy-avaśa-vartitā

"Giving up the study of many books and arts, of commentaries and disputes; freedom from meanness and faint-heartedness in worldly dealings; not yielding to grief and the like" ("Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu", 1.2.79–80).

This very rule had once puzzled him. Reading the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu" with his disciples, Guru Maharaj came to the sixty-four limbs of devotion — yet he himself preached widely, collected huge sums and built temples. What would he say of this verse? But in two words the guru dispelled all doubt: "Everything depends on capacity. One person can rule an empire and still have time to rest. Another wears himself out trying to cope with family cares, and still does not succeed." Each must do what is within his power.

Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math

In 1941 Srila Sridhar Maharaj founded the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math[7]. At first it was only a thatched hut on the bank of the Ganges, but even then he composed a shloka that foretold the future worldwide glory of the Math. The plot with its tumbledown hut was given to him by Sriyukta Sakhi Charan Ray, who bought it with his own money. Before that he had lived for some time in a rented house together with Sripad Keshava Maharaj, and sometimes at the math in Midnapore, where Sripad Jajabar Maharaj, Sripad Madhava Maharaj and others lived. In 1942, on the day of the Ratha-yatra, he came to this hut for the first time with his Govardhana-shila. "But here I lived separately," he recalled. At first there was

only one person with him; then another came and brought several devotees from Orissa; in time others joined as well, among them some of his godbrothers, and the mission began to grow.

śrīmach-chaitanya-sārasvata-maṭhavara-udgīta-kīrtir jaya-śrīṁ… — so begins the shloka he composed about the Math. It says that in Sri Nabadwip Dham, non-different from Vrindavan, on the bank of the Bhagirathi, in Koladwip, non-different from Govardhan, the King of Mountains, shines Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math; the followers of Sri Rupa who live there, in strict adherence to the line of Sri Sri Rupa-Raghunath, constantly chant the glories of Sri Gaurasundar and long to serve Sri Sri Guru Gauranga Gandharva Govindasundar, and the victory flag of the Math's renown soars ever higher. The English translation of the shloka printed in "Sri Guru and His Grace" was made from the Bengali translation by Srila Govinda Maharaj. Today the Math has centres in Nabadwip (Kolerganj) and in Bhanjipur near Tarakeshwar (Hooghly district), and elsewhere in India and throughout the world.

The Math stands in Kuliya, ancient Koladvipa, where Devananda Pandita lived — at the place called aparadha-bhanjana, "where offences are forgiven": here Mahaprabhu forgave all who had once offended Him in Navadvip. It was here, to the feet of the Lord who forgives the fallen, that he had longed to come when he left Vrindavan. The lake beside the Math was revealed to him as Govinda-kunda — the very one in Vrindavan, manifest in Navadvip as well; under Srila Govinda Maharaj there rose on its banks the main temple of the Math, a temple of Shiva, the Nat-mandir, the Chandan-yatra-mandir and other buildings.

He explained the name of the Math thus: "'Chaitanya Saraswat' points to the succession that runs from Chaitanya to Sarasvati, our Gurudeva": here Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's teaching is presented in its true light, and "the purity of his teaching is the object of our care. Our mission is the preservation, preaching, propagation and development of the teaching of our whole guru-parampara from Chaitanya to Sarasvati."

Many godbrothers saw in him the acharya of the Rupanuga line and came to him for counsel. At their request he gave sannyasa to Srila Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj, to Srila Bhakti Prajnana Keshava Maharaj — his first sannyasa disciple — to Bhakti Aloka Paramahamsa Maharaj, Bhakti Kamal Madhusudan Maharaj, Narasimha Maharaj, Bhagavat Maharaj, Acharya Maharaj and others; practically all the senior disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta either took sannyasa from him or asked him from whom to take it. Many regarded him as their shiksha-guru — among them Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami, Bhakti Prajnana Keshava, Bhakti Saranga Goswami, Bhakti Dayita Madhava and Bhakti Pramoda Puri. Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji, Bhakti Pramoda Puri and other revered Vaishnavas were convinced that Srila Sarasvati Thakura had passed the authority of acharya of the Rupanuga Sampradaya to him. Bhakti Pramoda Puri, Bhakti Prajnana Keshava and Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji remained his close companions all their lives, and Srila Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj, too, received his blessings and close association.

Once, during a parikrama of Vrindavan, on his appearance day, Srila Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj, one of the senior preachers among Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's disciples, himself worshipped him — offering incense and a lamp of a hundred and eight wicks — in the presence of many of his own disciples and godbrothers. Srila Govinda Maharaj recorded his words on tape: "Going forward, the lion often looks back. In Sanskrit this is called simhavalokanam. We go forward, putting all our strength into preaching, but sometimes we look back to learn what Srila Sridhar Maharaj thinks of it."

Writings

His first book was the "Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam" — "The Nectar of Immortality for the Surrendered Soul". It is a poem woven from many verses of the scriptures and of the Vaishnavas of the

past and from his own Sanskrit aphorisms; step by step it unfolds the six limbs of sharanagati, surrender to the Lord, and stands as a thorough study of this science on the evidence of the shastras.

In Sanskrit he composed other outstanding works as well: the “Prabhupada-padma-stavakah”, a poem in glorification of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, and the “Sri Sri Prema-dhama-deva-stotram”, an exceedingly beautiful poem on the deeds and teachings of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu; Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji used to say that Srila Rupa Gosvami himself is present in it. Sridhar Maharaj composed a wealth of songs, prayers and commentaries, both Bengali and Sanskrit; foremost among them are his commentaries on Srila Bhaktivinoda’s “Sharanagati” and his Bengali translations of the “Bhagavad-gita” and the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu”.

Krishnadasa Babaji often visited Hapania, Sridhar Maharaj’s birthplace, and would ask the villagers, “Is this where Srila Sridhar Maharaj studied? Is this the pond where he bathed?” Once Sridhar Maharaj asked him, “You are my godbrother — why do you visit the place of my birth?” — “Because I consider your works non-different from the writings of Srila Rupa Gosvami. I go there to put on my head the dust of the land where you displayed your pastimes.” According to one of the biographies, the Babaji also said that he saw no difference between his writings and those of Narottama Dasa Thakura.

He placed his own commentary on the “Bhagavad-gita” in the line of the works of the succession: “In our line the ‘Bhagavad-gita’ was commented on by Srila Vishvanatha Chakravarti Thakura, Srila Baladeva Vidyabhushana and other teachers. Some verses were explained by Srila Jiva Gosvami.” Srila Bhaktivinoda, translating the “Gita” into Bengali, relied mainly on Baladeva and Vishvanatha, while the original commentaries on the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” are held to be those of Sridhara Svami, which Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu Himself recognised. “I too tried to shed new light on some verses of the ‘Bhagavad-gita’,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj said: drawing on the previous teachers, he showed how the “Gita” unfolds the ideas of madhura-rasa and of its highest manifestation, parakiya-rasa, the transcendental love of Vraja. Once he asked Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami what he thought of his interpretation and heard, “What can I say? Your interpretation is absolutely correct.” Discussing with him the verse of the “Gita” (10.10) *dadāmi buddhi-yogaṁ taṁ, yena mām upayānti te* — “I give them that buddhi-yoga by which they come to Me” — he concluded that the word “upayanti” here points to parakiya-rasa, and Swami Maharaj agreed: “Yes, what is meant here is precisely the parakiya-rasa of Vraja. Nothing else can be the highest conclusion of the ‘Bhagavad-gita’.”

The fruit of that youthful conviction that the gayatri is spiritual and will itself reveal its meaning was the “Gayatri-nigudhartha” — an explanation of the gayatri mantra in the spirit of the “Srimad-Bhagavatam”, from the standpoint of madhura-rasa; it is an outstanding gift to the heritage of Sri Rupa’s followers, and enlightened souls call it the highest treasure of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas. The “bharga”, the effulgence on which the gayatri meditates, is Srimati Radharani, Krishna’s svarupa-shakti, who manifests Herself as Goloka, as effulgence, and as the power of the Lord’s pastimes. The sound of the gayatri is the song of Krishna’s flute, full of love for Radha, and the hidden meaning of the mantra is “radha-padam dhimahi”: we meditate on Radha’s feet, we serve Her. This is Mahaprabhu’s highest teaching.

Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj wrote that this understanding of the Brahma-gayatri as centred on Srimati Radharani was revealed to Sridhar Maharaj in the depth of realisation by the mercy of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, and that it is the best path to Krishna’s mercy. He recalled the words of the Upanishads, “shabalach chhyamam prapadye” — “through the Fair One I come to the Dark One”, through Radha to Krishna. For his gift of revealing to sincere souls the hidden meaning of the Lord’s pastimes of love, “Deva” was added to his name.

This meaning of the gayatri is imprinted in the emblem of his Math as well. As Srila Govinda Maharaj explained, Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, where sankirtan is always going on, is shown inside Krishna's flute, and from the Math the sound om, the very gist of the gayatri, comes forth radiating merciful rays. For, as Sridhar Maharaj explained, *gāyatrī muralīṣṭa-kīrtana-dhanaṁ rādhā-padaṁ dhīmahi*: "Krishna's flute does not make any other sound except for the glorification of Srimati Radharani." The emblem also keeps his image: the guru is water, the servitors of the Math are lotuses, and Radha-Krishna is the sun; if there is no water — if one cannot take shelter of Sri Guru and his grace — the lotus is burnt by the rays of the sun.

His Sanskrit verses are carved in marble at the Imlitala temple in Vrindavan, built by Srila Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj on the spot where Mahaprabhu sat beneath a tamarind (imli) tree when He came to Vrindavan. The verses speak of His pastime at that place and of the exact time of His coming to Vrindavan — a date usually considered unknown (the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and other books contain only hints of it), here conveyed by number-words, as is customary in Sanskrit prosody. His godbrothers could not fully grasp the meaning of the shloka; it was explained by the young Gaurendu Brahmachari. When some objected that this date differed from the one given by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, he replied, "Perhaps, but what my Guru Maharaj says is true, and I can prove it," — and proved it with quotations from the "Chaitanya-charitamrita".

His heritage was introduced to the West by Sripad Bhakti Sudhir Goswami Maharaj: the books "The Search for Sri Krishna, Reality the Beautiful", "Sri Guru and His Grace", "The Golden Volcano of Divine Love", "Subjective Evolution of Consciousness" and "Loving Search for the Lost Servant" opened a new depth in the understanding of Krishna consciousness[8]. Goswami Maharaj also wrote the book "Brothers" — about Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, his diksha-guru, and Srila Sridhar Maharaj, his shiksha- and sannyasa-guru. Sridhar Maharaj's explanation of Vasu Ghosha's song "yadi gaura na ha'ta" is quoted in his book by one of his disciples.

One of these books, "Sri Guru and His Grace" (1983), was gathered from his talks with devotees about Sri Guru; it was compiled and edited by Srila Bhakti Sudhir Goswami Maharaj and Sripad Bhakti Vidhan Mahayogi Maharaj. Its preface is a 1936 address by Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, its introduction his own essay of 1934; the book went through five printings (1983–2013), and in 2023 it appeared in electronic form as well. Its closing words gave it its name: we should never search for our fortune in the mud, but always look to the high sky and pray for Sri Guru and His Grace. In the list of the Math's English publications seventeen books stand under his name — among them, besides the five just named, the English editions of "Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam" and "Sri Sri Prema-dhama-devam Stotram" spoken of above, and the four volumes of "Sermons of the Guardian of Devotion".

The main thoughts of these talks are simple and deep. The succession of gurus is above all a succession of instruction, the siksa-guru parampara: it "follows the ideal, not the body", and the guru is recognized by the substance of his teaching, not by outward form. "We are slaves of the truth," he said: wherever the pure current of truth descends, there we bow our heads. One who has received nectar from his guru must be ready to pass it on to others even at his own risk: "I may go to hell, but I must carry out the order of my gurudeva" — and such a one the Lord will not forsake. Yet "even an acharya should consider that he is a student, and not a finished professor who has everything." Nor should a Vaishnava be judged by the magnitude of his outward activity: the preacher who loves the company of devotees (gosthyanandi) and the one who prefers solitude (viviktanandi) both do what Krishna entrusts to them — the key is in His hand.

Brothers: Sridhar Maharaj and Bhaktivedanta Swami

A special chapter of his life is his friendship with Abhay Charan De, the future Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada. They first met in 1930 in Allahabad. “At that time he had not yet accepted sannyasa,” Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami recalled many years later: Sridhar Maharaj had left home and come to Allahabad as a vanaprastha, dressed in white. “Krishna and Prabhupada chose him to prepare me,” he said (here, as in Sridhar Maharaj’s own words, “Prabhupada” means Srila Bhaktisiddhanta). Sridhar Maharaj lived in his house for many years; for more than five years they were in close association, often for five to seven hours a day, and Abhay, seeing in him a pure devotee, always took his instructions and advice very seriously. Though they were godbrothers, he invariably addressed him as “Your Divine Grace” and “Om Vishnupad” — forms of address used only for one’s spiritual master.

They preached together, too. In Bombay, where Abhay, then still a householder, had a business office, they opened a local temple of the Gaudiya Math and organised two parties to collect donations; one of them consisted of Abhay, Sridhar Maharaj and Bhakti Saranga Goswami Maharaj. Calling on Abhay’s colleagues, the pharmacists, they collected about five thousand rupees: “I made the acquaintances, Sridhar Maharaj preached, and Goswami Maharaj collected the donations.” By the recollections of others, Abhay often accompanied Sridhar Maharaj to preaching programmes and played the mridanga, and when Sridhar Maharaj was ill he led the party himself — singing kirtana and lecturing on the “Srimad-Bhagavatam”. With him Abhay also discussed his misfortunes — failures in business and discord in the family — seeking their spiritual benefit, and he highly valued his gift of bringing out the very essence of the scriptures.

Once in Bombay they received a sannyasi of the Gaudiya Math who had returned from Europe: to their surprise, he had neither tridanda, nor shikha, nor sannyasi dress. He said that in the West he had been asked questions that could not be answered. Abhay began to ask what those questions were, and Sridhar Maharaj answered them all, one after another. And Abhay exclaimed, “Today Asia has conquered Europe!”

In Calcutta Abhay rented two houses on Sitakanta Banerjee Lane; one housed his pharmaceutical laboratory, and its upper rooms he gave to Sridhar Maharaj and his disciples — among them the young Gaurendu Brahmachari. When leaving Calcutta, Sridhar Maharaj told Gaurendu to study the “Gita” under Abhay, and he often took him along on his preaching tours. Abhay was then translating the “Bhagavad-gita” into English and writing a commentary on it, discussing it with Sridhar Maharaj; later the manuscript was burnt through an employee’s negligence. “When Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada began his translation of the ‘Bhagavad-gita’, he consulted me on many questions,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj said in March 1982. Abhay also helped to publish Sridhar Maharaj’s first book. Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled how he said to his sister Bhavini Didi, whom they also called Pishima: “The ‘Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam’ is a much-needed and wonderful book. You have money. Please help to publish this book,” — and the first edition came out with her money.

The title “Bhaktivedanta”, which became known to the whole world, was given to Abhay Charan by none other than Sridhar Maharaj. After the Gaudiya Math broke apart many senior Vaishnavas took his shelter, and with difficult questions his godbrothers came to him. In 1959 sannyasa was given to Bhaktivedanta Prabhu by Srila Bhakti Prajnana Keshava Maharaj, Sridhar Maharaj’s first sannyasa disciple, who kept his title and gave him the name “Swami”. Setting out for America in 1965 on the “Jaladuta”, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami carried among his few books the “Srimad-Bhagavatam” and the “Sri Sri Prapanna-jivanamritam”. And when some disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta were displeased that Bhaktivedanta Swami was being called “Prabhupada” — a name once used only for their guru — Sridhar Maharaj rejoiced: “Yes, Prabhupada — he is fully worthy of this name.”

In 1967, returning from America, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami stayed with him at the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math and took part in the celebration of his Vyasa-puja. He wrote to a disciple: “My godbrother B. R. Sridhar Maharaj has given us a whole house. He has also agreed to cooperate with our society. We shall celebrate his birthday, and our brahmacharis will learn how to celebrate the birthday of their spiritual master.” At that time he also proposed that Sridhar Maharaj become president of his young International Society for Krishna Consciousness. Seeing how absorbed the two godbrothers were in conversation, Swami Maharaj’s disciple Achyutananda later asked what they had spoken of, and heard: “If I tell you, you will faint. Sridhar Maharaj is an extraordinarily elevated soul!”

Disciples deprived of his direct guidance Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami would send to Sridhar Maharaj. In one letter he writes that he can refer a disciple “to one who is most highly competent of all my god-brothers. This is B.R. Sridhara Maharaja, whom I consider to be even my siksa guru,” and advises: “live peacefully with Sridhara Maharaja” (Letter to Hrsikesa, 31 January 1969). Sridhar Maharaj, for his part, admired him: “What our Swami Maharaj has done is a miracle! What Bhaktivinoda Thakura conceived, Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura began to put into practice. And we see that through Swami Maharaj, at the end of his life, this plan has been fulfilled so completely. We are happy, we are glad, we are proud of it!” With tears in his eyes Swami Maharaj replied that everything had come by the mercy of Guru and the Vaishnavas, and asked Sridhar Maharaj to go on blessing him. “Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj has bored a tunnel through the mountain of the Western ego!” Srila Sridhar Maharaj said more than once.

Anxious about his health, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami wrote to Srila Govinda Maharaj: ask Sridhar Maharaj whether I should go to Vrindavan to leave my body there or remain in the West. Sridhar Maharaj dictated the reply: “Wherever you are, there is Vrindavan. Krishna is always with you and will always come to your aid. And if you should leave your body in New York, it will mean that Vrindavan has come to you in New York — do not doubt it.” Later Swami Maharaj wrote: “The instructions of Sripad Sridhar Maharaj I keep in the very core of my heart. Always and in everything he is my well-wisher. Certainly, after the departure of Prabhupada I should accept his guidance. And he has instructed me to remain in this country for good!” One of the biographies also writes of this letter — of the constant well-wisher whose instructions he accepts “on my head”.

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami sometimes stayed at his Math, and Sridhar Maharaj — always together with Srila Govinda Maharaj — visited him at the Chandrodaya Mandir in Mayapur. On 17 March 1973, at the opening of that temple, they sat on one vyasasana, and Swami Maharaj recalled: “I am very fortunate: for a long time, from about 1930, I have had the opportunity to associate with Srila Sridhar Maharaj. Maharaj, do you remember the time when you came to Allahabad and we met?” — and added: “I always knew he is a real Vaishnava.” Sridhar Maharaj was unwell, and at his request Srila Govinda Maharaj spoke in his place. He began with a verse of Raghupati Upadhyaya, which Krishnadasa Kaviraja also quotes: “To whom shall I tell it, and who will believe me, that the Supreme Absolute Truth is the beloved of the young cowherd girls in the groves by the river Yamuna?” (CC, Madhya 19.98) — who would believe that Abhay Babu, the householder everyone knew from the Gaudiya Math programmes, had become a world acharya? And he said that Swami Maharaj accepted Sridhar Maharaj as his shiksha-guru. Swami Maharaj confirmed: “I love him as my own son, and his Gurudeva, Sridhar Maharaj, I consider my shiksha-guru.” “He glorified me, calling me ‘Om Vishnupad’,” Srila Sridhar Maharaj recalled.

Despite Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami’s many requests, Sridhar Maharaj never went to preach outside India: “I did not want to become a big man. It is not in my nature. I would not like to be surrounded by crowds. I am content with what I have. Reflection on the spiritual is my life. To live by the conclusions of the scriptures and the counsel of the mahajanas, to discuss them in the circle of close devotees — that

is the main purpose of my life."

In March 1977, shortly before his departure, Swami Maharaj came to him in Navadvip for the last time: "I do not know how much longer I shall last, so I have come to see Sridhar." He asked him to settle in Mayapur: Srila Prabhupada [Bhaktisiddhanta] had always wanted Sridhar Maharaj to preach and had told him more than once, "Why don't you drag him out?"; the disciples would build a house where they would live together, with a lift and a car; "Sometimes I need to consult someone, but I have no one who could give good advice, and I need it very much." Sridhar Maharaj answered: "Yes, as long as I have strength, as long as I live, to fulfil Prabhupada's desire…" Yet he never moved, and later explained it thus: "At that time I did not think I would live longer than he, and so I promised to come to Mayapur whenever possible." In that conversation Swami Maharaj also spoke of the planetarium. Sridhar Maharaj dearly loved Srila Sanatana Gosvami's "Brihad-bhagavatamrita" and dreamed of an exhibition where dioramas would depict the worlds of the spiritual sky described in it, up to Goloka Vrindavan; unable to build it himself, he proposed it to Swami Maharaj, who took up the idea with enthusiasm: "The planetarium will be built under your direction."

After Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami's departure Sridhar Maharaj said: "I consider him a shaktyavesha-avatara." The proof is both the verses he wrote while crossing the Atlantic and all that he accomplished in the West. In the "Prayer to the Lotus Feet of Krishna" Swami Maharaj, seeing in his guru, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, the embodiment of Srimati Radharani, and in his order a service to Her, humbly deems himself unworthy of that service and asks Krishna to serve his guru; and in answer to this sincere prayer a special divine power descended: "Otherwise all this would have been impossible." Sridhar Maharaj composed for him a pranama-mantra, recited daily in the centres of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math:

namaḥ oṁ viṣṇupādāya kṛṣṇa-preṣṭhāya bhū-tale svāmī-śrī-bhaktivedānta-prabhupādāya te namaḥ gurv-ājñāṁ śirasi-dhṛtvā śakty-āveśa-sva-rūpiṇe hare-kṛṣṇeti mantreṇa pāścātya-prācya-tāriṇe viśvācārya-prabaryāya divya-kāruṇya-mūrtaye śrī-bhāgavata-mādhurya-gītā-jñāna-pradāyine gaura-śrī-rūpa-siddhānta-sarasvatī-niṣeviṇe rādhā-kṛṣṇa-padāmbhoja-bhṛṅgāya gurave namaḥ

"Obeisance to you, Om Vishnupada, so dear to Krishna here on earth — Swami Sri Bhaktivedanta Prabhupada! Obeisance to him who, taking the order of his guru upon his head, became a shaktyavesha, an embodiment of the Lord's special power, and by the mantra Hare Krishna delivered both West and East; to the best of the world's acharyas, the embodiment of divine compassion, the giver of the sweetness of the 'Bhagavatam' and the knowledge of the 'Gita'; to the devoted servant of Gaura, Sri Rupa and Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati; to the bee at the lotus feet of Radha and Krishna — to the guru, obeisance."

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami advised his senior disciples that if the need arose to consult higher spiritual authority after his disappearance, they should consult his senior godbrother, Srila Sridhar Maharaj; on more than one occasion he said, "I consider Srila Sridhar Maharaj to be my siksa-guru, instructing spiritual master, so what to speak of the benefit that others can have from his association." Just after his disappearance his senior disciples came to Sridhar Maharaj and asked his advice on how to guide the International Society for Krishna Consciousness; excerpts of these conversations entered the book "Sri Guru and His Grace". The disciple is like a lotus, he told them, the guru like the water, and Krishna like the sun: as long as the lotus floats on the water, the sun nourishes it, but without water that very sun will burn it; to retain the memory of the guru in his separation is the highest test. With his disciples the acharya must have absolute authority, yet two dangers threaten him: partiality to his disciples at the expense of his godbrothers, and deviation; and the constitution of a society must not bind the acharya and stifle faith: "The giving of love will conquer more than the giving of law." Those who had received the Holy Name from Bhaktivedanta Swami and the gayatri from one of his disciples he advised to

honour first of all Prabhupada, “who is the nama-guru, the guru of guru”, and then the diksha-guru. Before them, too, he glorified Swami Maharaj. To go with the Name to every village was the design of ISKCON: “That was the aim of Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, and we understand and appreciate that.” “Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada went the length and breadth of the world with Krishna consciousness. The fact that you have all come here is due to his earnestness. He has gone to the upper world, and so, in his name we are going on with some sort of transaction.” Swami Maharaj, he said, had laid stress among the Westerners on devotion to Nityananda and “distributed the key widely” to the chest of jewels left in the scriptures; and of himself: “This is not mine. This is the property of my gurudeva.”

Later, too, many followers of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, on his advice, turned to Sridhar Maharaj for guidance, and he revealed to them the depth of Vaishnavism. He taught that the spiritual revolution takes place within a person: first one must change oneself — and then the world around will change; direct service to Krishna attracts only beginners, while devotees of a higher level seek the Lord’s mercy by pleasing His intimate servants — the guru and his circle, and ultimately Nityananda Prabhu and Srimati Radharani. Thus Sripad B. A. Sagar Maharaj, one of the first disciples of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami, accepted Sridhar Maharaj’s guidance on his recommendation, and Sridhar Maharaj became his sannyasa-guru. Comparing Sridhar Maharaj with another of his godbrothers, Keshava Maharaj, Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami is remembered to have said that the first possessed depth and the second breadth. So in the lives of the two brothers their special lila was revealed: the younger saw in the elder his shiksha-guru, and the elder in the younger a shaktyavesha-avatara.

The Disciple and Successor

In the spring of 1947 a sankirtana party from the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math came to Nandaghat, and a seventeen-year-old youth — the future Srila Govinda Maharaj — went with it to Navadvip. He came to the feet of Sridhar Maharaj on the day of Nrisimha Chaturdashi. Sridhar Maharaj asked him two questions: could he stay in the Math and dedicate his whole life to service — and would he follow the instructions of his guru and not his own mind? The youth answered “yes” without the slightest hesitation. And Sripad Krishnadasa Babaji then said to Sridhar Maharaj, “Please give special attention to Sri Gaurendu Brahmachari — he is very intelligent and has outstanding qualities.”

By a rule he himself had laid down, a newcomer waited at least six months for initiation; but here Sridhar Maharaj broke his own rule: only a month later, at the Ratha-yatra, he initiated the youth and gave him the name Gaurendu Brahmachari, and a week after that he introduced him to his godbrothers as his successor. Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji accepted the youth as his own son; Bhakti Prajnana Keshava, Bhakti Saranga Goswami, Sakhi Babu, Ram Gopal Babu, Madhava Maharaj and Jajabar Maharaj spoke of his extraordinary gifts — and this confirmed Sridhar Maharaj in his decision to make Gaurendu his successor and the acharya of the Math. He drew him close as his personal servant and himself taught him the truths of the scriptures, Vaishnava etiquette and Sanskrit poetics; for more than forty years Srila Govinda Maharaj was his trusted servant and personal physician. The choice of a young and almost unknown disciple surprised many, but Sridhar Maharaj stood firm and asked those who disagreed to leave the society. “This youth will become a great saint and will deliver thousands of souls,” he foretold.

When Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami was in Mathura, Keshava Maharaj told him that Sridhar Maharaj intended to publish a journal, the “Gaudiya Darshan”; and in his very first letter from America, addressed to Govinda Maharaj, Swami Maharaj rejoiced at the first issues received “from the Math of Sripad Sridhar Maharaj in Navadvip”: “He has an excellent assistant in young Govinda Maharaj, and I think this is a very fortunate choice.”

A pro-rector of Calcutta University who had heard Gaurendu debate said to Sridhar Maharaj, “Pay attention to this youth. He will make your name glorious.” Once, because of a severe migraine, Sridhar Maharaj sent the twenty-one-year-old Gaurendu in his place to speak on the “Srimad-Bhagavatam” at a memorial gathering in the house of the Calcutta businessman Sri Satkari Banerjee; the host later said that the listeners — among them at least eight doctors of philosophy — were satisfied in the highest degree: “This boy has satisfied our intellectual hunger.” It was Satkari Banerjee who paid all the expenses of the installation of the Deities at the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math. In Chaitanyapur, at a zamindar’s house, they were expecting Sridhar Maharaj himself, but Gaurendu came — and answered every question. One zamindar said to Sridhar Maharaj of the brahmachari he had sent: “He appeared like a little cobra…”

Sridhar Maharaj spoke of his disciple with love: “Many times I have seen that his advice helped me in the most varied situations… Certainly he has siddhis”; “He never saw our Guru Maharaj, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, yet there is so much in common in their convictions, as if they had associated many times.” The story of how young Gaurendu asked a sannyasi reputed to be a great pandit whether God can commit suicide he often recalled, but added that such a question should not be asked.

Once, setting out for Vrindavan with his disciples, Sridhar Maharaj met at the station Sripad Bhakti Pradipa Tirtha Maharaj with his disciples; relations between them were not very close at the time. Gaurendu asked, “Tirtha Maharaj is here. I feel I should offer him my respects. Will you allow me to do so?” — “Yes, of course,” Sridhar Maharaj replied.

Sridhar Maharaj discussed his compositions with Govinda Maharaj, an expert in alankara, Sanskrit poetics: when he was pondering a shloka, his disciple would suggest variants. Some of these shlokas have not been published, and many were never written down — they are known only from Srila Govinda Maharaj. Under Sridhar Maharaj’s guidance Ram Gopal Babu, too, worked on the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” — a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, a Master of Arts of Calcutta University and zamindar of the Sampal district.

For forty years Sridhar Maharaj prepared his disciple for the service of acharya and had long insisted that he take sannyasa: “After you accept sannyasa, I will hand over all my duties to you.” By 1964 Gaurendu was still not a sannyasi, which greatly grieved Guru Maharaj. At last, in 1985, he called his disciple: “The day after tomorrow you will accept sannyasa,” — and to the request for three months he answered, “No, you will accept sannyasa the day after tomorrow, otherwise I shall die today.” He invited Sripad Puri Maharaj, and two days later, when he arrived, Srila Govinda Maharaj accepted sannyasa. The next morning was Sridhar Maharaj’s own appearance day. “Srila Guru Maharaj, yesterday you gave sannyasa to Srila Govinda Maharaj, but I think he accepted sannyasa many, many lifetimes ago,” Sripad B. A. Sagar Maharaj said to him. “You mean that this was done only to show people his true position, but in fact he has held it for a long time?” Guru Maharaj replied, and, smiling and laughing, spoke for hours about his disciple. “It was the appearance day of the Guru himself, but the Guru was performing kirtana to his disciple!” Sagar Maharaj recalled. For more than three hours at his Vyasa-puja he glorified Srila Govinda Maharaj — his deep understanding of the scriptures, his ability to harmonise everything, his exalted devotional nature, his serious and responsible approach to every task. On Gaura-purnima 1986 he proclaimed Srila Govinda Maharaj acharya of the mission, handed over to him all his authority and himself seated him in his own acharya’s chair[9].

In his will he briefly explained why he had chosen Srila Govinda Maharaj as acharya. From Gaura-purnima 1986 until his departure he no longer accepted disciples, and when Govinda Maharaj was away from the Math he himself gave initiation — in his disciple’s name. There was a time when, citing his advanced age, he had decided to accept no disciples at all, and began to initiate people from the West only after his beloved disciple vowed to him to take care of the Deities, the mission and all the

devotees.

Once he said to his disciple, “I consider your spiritual position higher than mine,” and explained: “I have often found that your advice and suggestions are very valuable to me. Before, it was so only with Vasudeva Prabhu. In any case, I often have the feeling that you are more qualified than I.” He composed a pranama-mantra for Srila Govinda Maharaj — a case unprecedented in the history of the sampradaya, when the teacher glorifies his disciple — and ordered his picture to be placed on the altar for daily worship. He often said, “Srila Govinda Maharaj is a paramahamsa by his very nature.”

gurvābhīṣṭa-supūrakaṁ guru-gaṇair āśīṣa-sambhūṣitaṁ cintyācintya-samasta-veda-nipuṇaṁ śrī-rūpa-panthānugam govindābhidham ujjvalaṁ vara-tanuṁ bhakty-anvitaṁ sundaraṁ vande viśva-guruñ ca divya-bhagavat-premṇo hi bīja-pradam

“I bow to him who perfectly fulfils the innermost desires of his guru, who is adorned with the blessings of the whole guru-varga, who is versed in all the Vedas — in the conceivable and the inconceivable — and follows the path of Sri Rupa; to him who is called Govinda, radiant, beautiful of form, full of devotion — the teacher of the world, the giver of the seed of divine love for the Lord.”

He taught that the relationship of guru and disciple is not limited to dasya-rasa, the relation of master and servant: it can be friendly, and at times even coloured by the parental feeling of a disciple who surrounds his Gurudeva with care and attention.

Sripad Bhakti Sudhir Goswami Maharaj recalled his words: “In fact, in many respects Srila Govinda Maharaj is more qualified than I.” Shortly before his departure, seeing Goswami Maharaj off to the West, Sridhar Maharaj called him to his bedside, took him firmly by the shoulders and said: “Goswami Maharaj, this may be my last instruction to you... My sincere and ardent desire is — help Govinda Maharaj. Do you promise?”

Last Years and Departure

When he spoke of the Lord’s pastimes his speech was wondrous: his voice and every movement breathed love, and one disciple called him “beauty, sweetness and charm in motion”. In his later years devotees came from all over the world to hear from him the teaching of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and the previous acharyas, and he spoke with them at length. His talks were preserved on tape and on film, then transcribed, and the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math and his followers publish them.

Having handed over the post of acharya, he withdrew into his room and spent the last years of his manifest pastimes in deep experience of divine separation from the Lord and in longing to serve Sri Sri Radha-Govinda. In June 1988, as Sripad Shrutashrava Prabhu recalled, hardly anyone was admitted to him any more except Srila Govinda Maharaj; when he came in and sat beside him, Guru Maharaj was transformed: with one arm he embraced him, and in the other hand he held his palm. (On his very first visit, at Gaura-purnima, Shrutashrava had seen Govinda Maharaj singing verses of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” to Sridhar Maharaj to please him.)

Srila Bhakti Rakshaka Sridhar Deva Goswami Maharaj entered the eternal pastimes on 12 August 1988, on the Amavasya of the month of Sridhara, in the ninety-third year of his life[10].

A year later, in 1989, on his appearance day, Srila B. K. Tapasvi Maharaj said to the devotees gathered at the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math: “Srila Sridhar Maharaj was an outstanding follower of our Gurudeva, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Goswami Maharaj, and he chose Srila Govinda Maharaj as his successor. Therefore, my dear devotees, please accept him as the successor of Srila Sridhar Maharaj.” Srila Govinda Maharaj was blessed also by Sridhar Maharaj’s godbrothers — B. V. Jajabar Maharaj, B. D. Madhava Maharaj, Krishnadasa Babaji Maharaj, B. P. Puri Maharaj, B. K. Shanta

Maharaj and Satprasangananda Prabhu.

Legacy

The whole life of Srila Sridhar Maharaj was an embodiment of sharanagati, and all his gifts are imbued with the spirit of surrender; but his most generous gift was a sharanagata-bhakta — Srila Govinda Maharaj. “The precious gift of Srila Sridhar Maharaj to the whole world was his beloved disciple and successor, Srila Govinda Maharaj,” they say in his mission. From 1992 Srila Govinda Maharaj preached all over the world, and through him people of more than forty countries came to know the life and teaching of Sridhar Maharaj. In 1995 his book “Sri Guru and His Grace” appeared in Russian for the first time.

Srila Govinda Maharaj said: “Srila Sridhar Maharaj is my diksha- and shiksha-guru. Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami Maharaj, by the mercy of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, is also my shiksha-guru.” Both of them gave the world the Hare Krishna maha-mantra, and “they did not intend to create sects — why should we do so?” “I am a disciple of Srila Sridhar Maharaj, and from my youth I adopted his attitude to the world. In everyone I see a friend.”

Sripad B. V. Goswami Maharaj, who first came to Sridhar Maharaj’s temple in Santa Fe and began his acquaintance with his books with “Sri Guru and His Grace”, said in Moscow on 26 October 2005 — on Sridhar Maharaj’s Vyasa-puja, the hundred and eleventh anniversary of his appearance — that with Sridhar Maharaj a familiar theme often takes an unexpected turn that opens a new depth in it. Thus, speaking of Srimati Radharani, he said that we are in essence shaktas; not worshippers of mundane power, but shuddha-shaktas: Srimati Radharani is the shuddha-shakti, the pure internal potency of the Lord. In this he follows Srila Bhaktisiddhanta: “They worship Radharani because She is dear to Krishna, but we worship Krishna because He is dear to Radharani.” A new depth was opened also by his exposition of the five levels of knowledge — pratyaksha, paroksha, aparoksha, adhokshaja and aprakrita.

In the books of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math he is the Founder-Acharya; among the great disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta he is named first. His life and teachings were briefly described by Sripad B. A. Sagar Maharaj in the book “Srila Guru Maharaj: His Divine Pastimes and Teachings in Brief”, and recordings of his talks are collected in an audio archive (sridharmaharaj.ru). Many devoted followers carry his teaching through the world to this day.

In the chart of the disciplic succession printed in “Sri Guru and His Grace”, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta is followed by him (beside him, in brackets, Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami), after him comes Srila B. S. Govinda Dev-Goswami Maharaj, and then Srila B. N. Acharya Maharaj and Srila B. T. Niriha Maharaj.

1. The day of his appearance is given in “Nashi uchitelya” (“Our Teachers”), a book of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math; one of the biographies gives only the year and the place. That day was the Krishna Navami of the month of Damodara — the day on which his appearance is observed according to our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math). The translator of another biography notes that the appearance of Virachandra is observed on the same day.

2. The name given at birth is recorded in “Our Teachers”. In Madras, by his own account, he was known as “Sri Ramendrasundar Bhattacharya, Bachelor of Arts”.

3. “Our Teachers” does not give the year of initiation: it says that in 1926 he left home and joined the mission. One of the biographies dates his initiation to 1927. The two accounts do not contradict each other.

4. One of the biographies gives the year of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta’s departure differently in different chapters — 1936 and 1937.

5. According to one of the biographies, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta asked for this song on the morning of the very day of his departure, and “tuhu doya-sagara” was sung by Navina Krishna Vidyalankara. The account of Srila Govinda Maharaj and Srila Sridhar Maharaj’s own words (“exactly one day before his departure”) place it on the eve of the departure; we follow them here.

6. The verse quoted (“Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu”, 1.2.79–80) speaks of many books, commentaries and disputes; the rule not to bind oneself to disciples and not to embark on great undertakings (*śiṣyādy-ananubandhitvaṁ mahārambhādy-anudyamaḥ*) stands in the same list a line earlier (1.2.78). Cf. CC, Madhya 22.114: “One should not take a great number of disciples…”

7. The year of the founding is given in “Our Teachers”; the same book records his own recollection that he first came to the donated land on the day of the Ratha-yatra in 1942. According to one of the biographies, the Math was founded soon after Srila Bhaktisiddhanta’s departure.

8. “Our Teachers” names these books in its account of B. S. Goswami Maharaj — “his books”; they are the talks and writings of Srila Sridhar Maharaj in his editing and publication. One of the biographies expressly calls “Golden Volcano of Divine Love” a book of Srila Sridhar Maharaj. In the list of publications of Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math (in “Sri Guru and His Grace” itself) all five are named books of Srila Sridhar Maharaj; “Sri Guru and His Grace” was compiled and edited by B. S. Goswami Maharaj and B. V. Mahayogi Maharaj.

9. The order of events follows “Our Teachers”. There, in Srila Govinda Maharaj’s recollection, he accepted sannyasa in 1985 and was proclaimed acharya “two months later, at Gaura-purnima”; it is then said that Sridhar Maharaj seated him in his chair and “on the next day” glorified him at his Vyasa-puja; by the recollection of B. A. Sagar Maharaj, Sridhar Maharaj’s appearance day fell on the day after the sannyasa. The appearance day falls in the month of Damodara (autumn), Gaura-purnima in spring; the same book says that he accepted no disciples “from that day of Gaura-purnima 1986”. Hence here: sannyasa on the eve of the Vyasa-puja of 1985, proclamation as acharya on Gaura-purnima 1986.

10. The day of his departure is given in “Our Teachers”; it is the Amavasya of the month of Sridhara — the day on which his departure is observed according to our calendar. One of the biographies says “on the Amavasya of July”; this is inexact: in 1988 the Amavasya of the month of Sridhara fell in August.